

Is More Than Half the World's Population Using Social Media Cause for Concern?

The fact that 3.96 billion people, more than half of the world's population, used social media last year has frequently been presented as alarming. However, this figure reflects the scale of adoption rather than the nature of its effects. This essay argues that widespread social media use is not, in itself, a cause for concern. Instead, concern should focus on the specific practices, platform features and user beliefs that shape online experiences and determine whether they enhance or undermine well-being. From this perspective, the headline statistic is less a judgment than a starting point for further investigation. To support this argument, the discussion first considers why the figure generates anxiety, then explains why aggregate measures can be misleading, and finally examines the mechanisms and attitudes that account for both positive and negative outcomes.

At the outset, it is important to recognise that concerns about social media are neither irrational nor unsupported by evidence. According to Lee and Hancock (2024), researchers, technology experts and policymakers have all expressed worries that social media may contribute to depression, anxiety and problematic device use. Such concerns have attracted significant public attention, including congressional hearings in the United States, while many parents fear that excessive screen use may harm their children's mental health. Moreover, these anxieties are reflected in empirical research. Kross et al. (2021) report a study involving 37,729 participants across 18 countries, in which approximately one-fifth of respondents admitted comparing themselves unfavourably with others on Facebook during a two-week period. Although this represents a minority of users, the proportion translates into a substantial number of individuals when applied to platforms with billions of users. Consequently, the sheer scale of social media adoption can make relatively small individual harms appear to constitute a major societal problem.

Nevertheless, this same emphasis on scale illustrates why headline figures can be deceptive. Ortiz-Ospina (2019) argues that the relationship between social media use and well-being is both complex and reciprocal, making straightforward causal claims difficult to sustain. On the one hand, increased use is sometimes associated with later declines in life satisfaction. On the other hand, lower levels of life satisfaction may also encourage greater use of social media. In other words, causality appears to operate in both directions. Furthermore, even when causal effects have been identified, they tend to be relatively small. Lee and Hancock (2024) cite analyses of large, nationally representative datasets showing that digital technology accounts for only a limited proportion of variation in well-being, considerably less than established factors such as sleep, diet and exercise. Similarly, successive meta-analyses have reported small and inconsistent effects. Taken together, this evidence suggests that a large user base combined with a minimal average effect does not necessarily indicate a social crisis. Rather, the statistic appears alarming only when its underlying components are overlooked.

38 A further challenge to the assumption that widespread use inevitably leads to widespread
39 harm is the considerable variation in individual experiences. Evidence suggests that social
40 media affects different users in markedly different ways. **For example**, Beyens et al. (2021),
41 as summarised by Lee and Hancock (2024), found that social media use improved affective
42 well-being for 26% of adolescents, reduced it for 28%, and had no noticeable effect on the
43 remaining 45%. **As a result**, the overall average was close to zero **despite** the presence of
44 significant positive and negative outcomes within the sample. Two important conclusions
45 follow. **First**, claims that social media has only a "small effect" can be misleading **because**
46 they obscure substantial differences between individuals. **Second**, concerns directed at the
47 entire population miss the central issue. What matters is not that billions of people use
48 social media, **but that** some users are affected negatively **while** others benefit from it.
49 **Accordingly**, the key questions become not how many people use social media, **but** which
50 users experience harm and what factors explain those outcomes.

51 **If** overall user numbers are not the real source of concern, **then** attention should shift to the
52 mechanisms that distinguish harmful experiences from beneficial ones. Kross et al. (2021),
53 drawing on Goffman's theory of self-presentation, argue that everyday interactions in
54 offline settings are constrained by unpredictable circumstances, **whereas** social media
55 platforms allow individuals to construct highly curated versions of themselves. **As a result**,
56 users are frequently exposed to idealised portrayals of others, creating conditions that
57 encourage upward social comparison and, **in some cases**, feelings of inadequacy or distress.
58 **In addition**, certain platform features may facilitate more harmful forms of interaction.
59 **Because** social media often removes the social cues that encourage empathy in face-to-face
60 encounters and enables emotional responses to be shared instantly, it can lower barriers to
61 cyberbullying, trolling and the spread of moral outrage. Kross et al. further suggest that
62 these processes contribute to the dehumanisation of others and the intensification of social
63 divisions. **Importantly**, none of these outcomes arises simply because a platform has a large
64 number of users. **Instead**, they stem from specific design features and patterns of behaviour,
65 **although** their effects may be amplified when adopted at scale.

66 **At the same time**, users' beliefs about social media appear to play a significant role in
67 shaping their experiences. Lee and Hancock (2024) demonstrate that attitudes towards
68 social media are influenced by beliefs about both agency and valence. **In particular**,
69 individuals differ in whether they see themselves as controlling the platform or being
70 controlled by it, and whether they view its effects as beneficial or harmful. **Significantly**,
71 feelings of distress are most common among users who perceive a loss of control over their
72 engagement with social media. This finding suggests that subjective interpretations are not
73 merely consequences of use **but** are integral to the experience itself. The implication is clear.
74 **As** Ortiz-Ospina (2019) also argues, time spent online is an inadequate measure of risk. **As**
75 Przybylski memorably notes, researchers would not attempt to explain obesity simply by
76 measuring "food time". **By the same logic**, efforts to improve well-being should focus less on

77 screen-time limits and more on encouraging healthy forms of content, interaction and
78 engagement.

79 **Ultimately**, the evidence reviewed here suggests that the original question is framed too
80 broadly. The fact that more than half of the world's population uses social media is not, by
81 itself, a cause for concern. The statistic measures adoption, not harm. Genuine concern
82 arises only when attention is directed towards the specific social comparisons, platform
83 designs and beliefs about control that influence users' experiences. **In this respect**, Kross et
84 al. (2021) compare social media to the printing press: a transformative technology whose
85 full consequences remain uncertain. Such a comparison encourages neither panic nor
86 complacency. **Rather**, it highlights the need for precision. **Instead of** asking how many
87 people use social media, or how much time they spend online, researchers and
88 policymakers should focus on identifying who is harmed, by what mechanisms, and under
89 what conditions.